

Celebrating Lent and Holy Week



3-Minute Retreat

Before preparing the session, pause, be still, and be aware of the loving presence of God.

Tobit 4:7

Give alms from your possessions. Do not turn your face away from any of the poor, so that God's face will not be turned away from you.

Reflection

In this Scripture passage, Tobit, who knows he will die soon, turns over to his son Tobias some money he has kept aside. He instructs Tobias as to his use of this money, including to give alms to the poor. He tells Tobias that giving alms frees the giver from death and darkness. [Tobit 4:10]. The giving of alms is a spiritual discipline Jesus knew was taught in the Old Testament, which he then emphasized in his own teachings. People who have little are precious in God's sight; in helping with their difficulties, we walk in companionship with Jesus.

Question

How can I guide the children I catechize to find the ways they can give alms from their hearts?



Prayer

Pray, using this prayer or one of your own.

Jesus, help me see those who have little as precious in your sight so that I may share with an open heart.

Knowing and Sharing Your Faith in Session 20

Consider how Scripture and Tradition can deepen your understanding of the session content.

Scripture

Matthew 25:40 teaches us that when we help those who have little, we do it for Christ.

Luke 21:1–4 tells the story of a poor widow who gave all that she had to help others.

John 4:5–15 tells about Jesus' encounter with a woman at a well.

Tradition

Lent is the period of fasting preceding the celebration of Easter. It recalls Jesus' 40-day fast in the wilderness [Matthew 4:1–11]. Lent begins on Ash Wednesday and ends at the evening Mass of Holy Thursday. During Lent, the Church focuses on our need for God's forgiveness as individuals and as a community. We do so through the Lenten practices of fasting, almsgiving, and prayer.

Catholic Social Teaching

The integrated Catholic social teaching themes in this session are **Call to Family, Community, and Participation** and **Option for the Poor and Vulnerable**. See page 127b for explanations of these themes.

Window on the Catechism

The seasons and days of penance are discussed in CCC 1438.

General Directory for Catechesis

The organization of catechesis around the season of Lent is discussed in GDC 129.

1-Hour Session Planner

SESSION 20 Celebrating Lent and Holy Week

Session Theme: *Lent and Holy Week are times to think of how we treat others.*

Before This Session

- Determine whether you will use the Unit Assessment option listed on page 168.
- Determine whether you will also discuss the Lent and Holy Week seasonal pages in the back of the Children's Book.
- Bookmark your Bible to Matthew 25:40, Luke 21:1–4, and John 4:5–15. Place the Bible open to one of these passages in your Prayer Center.
- Read the Guide for this session, choose any additional multimedia content or If Time Allows activities that you might have time to complete, and gather the listed materials.

Scripture in Session 20

- Matthew 25:40
- Luke 21:1–4
- John 4:5–15

Prayer in Session 20

In prayer during this session, children ask Jesus for help in thinking of others' needs along with his guidance in providing assistance to meet those needs. Prayer includes time for children to talk with God in the silence of their hearts and share with him their thoughts and concerns.

STEPS		1 HOUR
ENGAGE	Celebrating Lent and Holy Week PAGE 163	
EXPLORE	We Grow in Virtue During Lent and Holy Week PAGE 164	
REFLECT	Mass During Lent and Holy Week PAGE 165 Art Print 20: Christ on the Cross ART PRINT AND PRINT BACK Jesus in the Desert PAGE 166	
RESPOND	Living My Faith PAGE 167	
AT HOME Scripture reading, discussion, and activity for families PAGE 168		

Materials

REQUIRED

- Bible
- Device with internet access and QR code reader
- Art Print 20: *Christ on the Cross* (easel)
- Music: "Song of Love"
- Art supplies

OPTIONAL

- Scripture BLM 20
- Activity BLM 20
- Scripture Prayer Service BLM 20
- Construction paper, yarn

- Assessment: Session 20 www.findinggod.com
- Assessment: Unit Assessment BLM 4

Celebrating Lent and Holy Week

SESSION
20

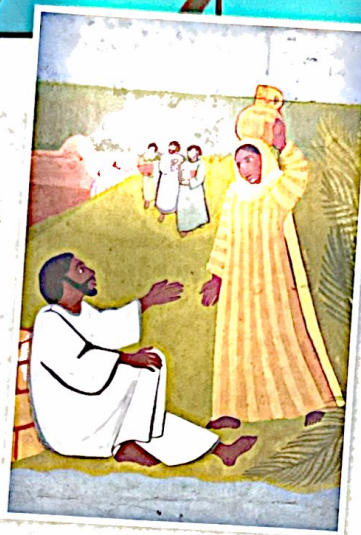


GOD'S WORD

Read and listen to
John 4:5–15.

The story of Jesus asking the Samaritan woman for a drink is a story of how we treat one another. In the story, Jesus breaks a barrier by making a request of a woman from another culture. During Lent, we think about how we treat each other and open ourselves to a new friendship with Jesus and with God his Father. As Jesus promises the woman something in return, we are promised something for our efforts during Lent.

Lent begins on Ash Wednesday. It is a time of 40 days of fasting, almsgiving, and prayer to prepare for Jesus' Resurrection on Easter. We remember that in Jesus there are no strangers or foreigners.



Prayer

Jesus, help me know you better and share what I learn with others. Help us all learn about people from different places and different backgrounds and know that we all live in your love.

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UNDERSTANDING SCRIPTURE

The story of Jesus and the Samaritan woman is one of the most moving in the Gospels. Their encounter is forbidden on many levels; a Jew should not interact with a Samaritan, the woman should not talk with a man, and Jesus, a Jew, may not drink from a container belonging to a non-Jew. Jesus throws all those taboos aside. The woman tells the people in her village about Jesus, the Messiah, and word of him begins to spread outside the Jewish community. The story is told during Lent because Lent is a time of examining things that keep us from God and breaking through those barriers.

IF TIME ALLOWS

Scripture BLM: John 4:5–15

Have children complete Scripture BLM 20 to gain a better understanding of the passage.



SESSION 20

OUTCOMES

- ▶ Retell the story of Jesus and the Samaritan woman at the well.
- ▶ Explain that Lent is a time to think about how we treat others.
- ▶ Describe practices and experiences of Lent and Holy Week.
- ▶ Define *almsgiving*, *intercessions*, and *Prayer of the Faithful*.

1 Open Your Heart

Invite children to quiet themselves and prepare to hear sacred Scripture.

2 Proclaim God's Word

Take the Bible from the Prayer Center. Read John 4:5–15. Then say: **The Gospel of the Lord.** Invite children to respond *Praise to you, Lord Jesus Christ.*

3 The Word Alive

Ask: **How do we treat new classmates who move here from another town or state?** (We welcome them.) Say: **During Lent, we are called to think of people from other places as members of our family.** Read the paragraphs aloud. Ask: **How are our lives different when we don't focus on differences?** (We make more friends. The good we do extends farther.)



Prayer

Ask a volunteer to pray the prayer aloud. Pray together the Sign of the Cross. End by praying *Amen.*



If appropriate and feasible, have children scan the code on page 163.

1 Begin

Ask: **What does the expression "put yourself in someone else's shoes" mean? (try to understand what that person is experiencing)** Say: **Lent is a time to be aware of other people's situations and to offer support.**

2 Connect

Have a volunteer read aloud the heading and the paragraphs under it. Invite volunteers to share their answers to the question.

† Have volunteers read aloud Almsgiving, including the Scripture. Have children find the word *almsgiving* in the Glossary. Discuss its meaning. Ask: **What did Jesus mean when he said the widow put in more than the rich people?** (The widow gave all she had. The rich people still had more than enough.)



Play for children "Song of Love." Say: **This is a song that tells us how we can reach out to others during Lent.**

ACTIVITY Read aloud Earn Money for Almsgiving and invite children to complete the activity with partners.

† *The Poor and Vulnerable*

3 Close

Direct children's attention to the feature on page 164.

† Reading God's Word

Have children read aloud the verse together. Discuss additional efforts we make during Lent to help others.

We Grow In Virtue During Lent and Holy Week

Lent is a time to think about how we treat others. We look beyond our own wants and desires. During Lent, we pay attention to the needs of others and respond by helping. We think about the way Jesus helped others.

What are some changes I can make during Lent to grow in how I serve God?



Almsgiving

People who were poor were looked down upon, but Jesus loved them.

When he looked up he saw some wealthy people putting their offerings into the treasury and he noticed a poor widow putting in two small coins. He said, "I tell you truly, this poor widow put in more than all the rest; for those others have all made offerings from their surplus wealth, but she, from her poverty, has offered her whole livelihood." *Luke 21:1-4*

During Lent we practice **almsgiving** by sharing money, time, and resources to help others.

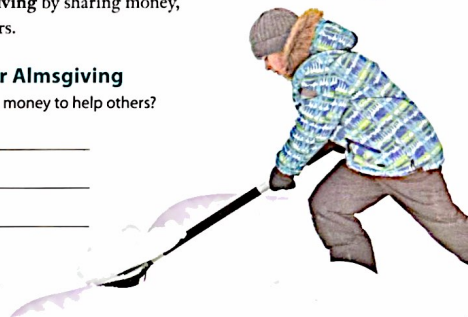
ACTIVITY: Earn Money for Almsgiving

What are three ways you could earn money to help others?

1. **Answers will vary.**
2. _____
3. _____

† Reading God's Word

Give alms from your possessions. Do not turn your face away from any of the poor, so that God's face will not be turned away from you. *Tobit 4:7*



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IF TIME ALLOWS

Activity BLM: Helping Others

Have children complete Activity BLM 20 to write a prayer for a friend in need.



Seasonal Sessions: Lent and Holy Week

Work with children through pages 221–228 of the Children's Book and this guide. These special sessions can each take up to one hour to complete.

IDEAS TO SHARE: Almsgiving

Pope Francis says of giving: "The gesture is important, helping those who ask, looking them in the eyes and touching their hands." Read this quote to children and ask how it is similar to the verse from Tobit on the page.

Mass During Lent and Holy Week

When we go to Mass throughout the year, we pray the **Prayer of the Faithful**, or general intercessions. This is a prayer for the needs of the Church, the world, and the local community. On Good Friday, we pray traditional ancient intercessions. These are solemn prayers. We stand for each prayer and then kneel to pray silently. We pray for those preparing to celebrate Baptism and for people who do not believe in God.

? Did You Know?

Lent is a time of almsgiving, prayer, and fasting. Jesus teaches about these practices in the Sermon on the Mount. The Sermon on the Mount appears in the Gospel of Matthew.

What We Experience

During Lent, you can see that the church looks simple and plain. This is a season of penance, so there are no flowers or decorations in the sanctuary. The priest wears purple vestments.

ACTIVITY: Lord, Hear Our Prayer

Complete these two prayers of intercession. In the first, pray for a need of your community. In the second, pray for a need of the world.

For **Answers will vary.** may God _____.

Let us pray to the Lord. Lord, hear our prayer.

For _____,

may God _____.

Let us pray to the Lord. Lord, hear our prayer.



SESSION 20 • Celebrating Lent and Holy Week 165

IF TIME ALLOWS

Scripture Prayer Service BLM:

John 4:5–15

For an optional prayer service focused on this session's opening Scripture passage, refer to Scripture Prayer Service BLM 20.



FOR THE CATECHIST



READ about praying with children.



INCLUSION

Hearing

As children read aloud the intercessions they wrote for the activity on page 165, invite them to include gestures and body language to support their prayers.

1 Begin

Ask: **What is a prayer of intercession?** (a prayer that asks God for help on behalf of another) Say: **Think of someone who has been on your mind lately or of people who are suffering from an event such as an earthquake. Pray an intercession for them.**

2 Connect

Read aloud the heading and the first paragraph. Say: **During Lent, we think of others. One way we do so is by praying for them.** Have children find *Prayer of the Faithful* and *intercession* in the Glossary and read aloud their definitions. Ask a volunteer to read aloud What We Experience.

ACTIVITY Read aloud the directions and ask children to complete the sentences independently. When all children have finished, go around the room as each child reads his or her intercessions. After each one, have the class as a whole say together, "Lord, hear our prayer."

✝ **Family and Community**

? Did You Know?

Read aloud the feature. Tell children that almsgiving, prayer, and fasting were familiar to the Jewish people to whom Jesus' family belonged. Jesus gave the practices new meaning.

3 Close

Use the following page and the Art Print easel to teach Art Print 20: *Christ on the Cross*.



If appropriate and feasible, have children scan the code on page 165.

1 Begin

Display the Art Print easel open to Art Print 20. Briefly introduce and discuss the artwork, using information from About the Artist and Art•i•facts. Ask: **What does the painting show?** (Jesus dying on the Cross) **What details do you notice in the painting, and what do you think they mean?** (Answers will vary.) **Why was Jesus there?** (to fulfill the promise of his Death and Resurrection) **During Lent, as we prepare our hearts for Easter, we remember the suffering Jesus accepted for us.**

2 Connect

+ Read aloud the introduction and discuss the question. Tell children that almsgiving, prayer, and fasting help us prepare our hearts during Lent.

Read aloud the first paragraph of Jesus in the Desert. Ask: **Why was Jesus in the desert?** (to prepare for the sacrifice he was going to make of himself for us) **What does it mean to fast?** (literally, to not eat) Say: **Giving something up can help us understand those who do not have it at all.** Read aloud the Scripture passage. Ask: **What do you think Jesus is saying?** (What we do for others, we do for Jesus.)

ACTIVITY Read aloud the directions. Ask children to think of a meaningful Lenten promise and write about it. Invite them to share their ideas.

3 Close

Invite children to reflect on the artwork and to pray a silent prayer to grow closer to God during Lent.

ART PRINT 20

Art Print 20 shows how Jesus sacrificed his life for us. How do you make your heart ready during Lent in remembrance of his sacrifice?

Jesus in the Desert

During Lent we remember how Jesus suffered and died before his Resurrection. To prepare for his sacrifice, he spent 40 days in the desert. During those 40 days, Jesus fasted and resisted temptation by the Devil. By caring for those in need and resisting temptation, we can make our hearts ready for Easter. Catholics abstain from meat on Fridays. Some Christians fast during Lent by choosing a food or an activity to give up. Others choose to do something to remind them of Jesus, such as pray every morning before school.

Jesus once said this in a parable.

"And the king will say to them in reply,
'Amen. I say to you, whatever you did
for one of these least brothers of mine,
you did for me.'"
Matthew 25:40



When you help others, you show you care for Jesus too.

ACTIVITY: A Lenten Promise

Write an idea for a Lenten promise. Choose something that would remind you daily of Christ's strength to resist temptation and his ultimate sacrifice—his Crucifixion.

Answers will vary.

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IF TIME ALLOWS

Art Studio: In the Desert

Have children look at the illustration on the page showing Jesus in the desert. Distribute paper and watercolor paint. Based on their reflection above, ask children to paint their own pictures showing Jesus in the desert.



Using the Art Print

For additional activities and prayer opportunities, see the Art Print back.

Living My Faith

Faith Summary

During Lent, we prepare for the celebration of Jesus' Resurrection. It is a time to think about how we can joyfully love others as Jesus did. We are encouraged to look beyond our own wants and desires. We become aware of others' needs and lovingly respond with help.

Words I Learned

almsgiving intercession Prayer of the Faithful

Ways of Being Like Jesus

Jesus treated others with kindness. *Reach out to others by being a good listener.*



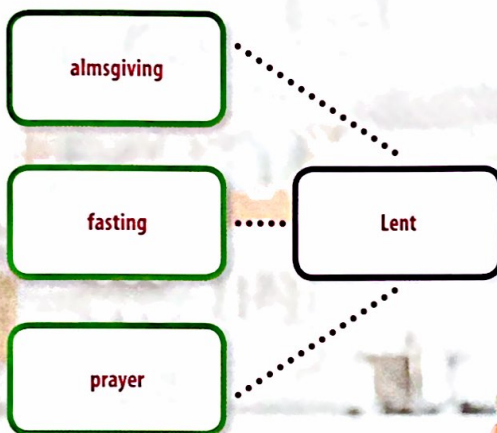
Prayer

Jesus, help me grow during Lent through prayer, fasting, and almsgiving.

ACTIVITY: What We Do During Lent

Write the words in the word web. The main topic should connect to the other three.

almsgiving fasting Lent prayer



SESSION 20 • Celebrating Lent and Holy Week 167

IF TIME ALLOWS



ACCESS an Interactive Session Review.



Lenten Practices

 Have children make an elaborated word web based on the one they did in the activity on page 167. Children can draw, label, and cut out from construction paper or from printouts from the internet pictures representing Lent, almsgiving, prayer, and fasting. Then have children arrange the pictures around the image for Lent in the center of a large sheet of construction paper and glue the pictures to the paper. Have children add pieces of string or yarn to connect them to the image of Lent in the center.

1 Begin

Faith Summary Ask a volunteer to read aloud this section. Ask: **For what do we prepare our hearts as we think of Jesus in the desert during Lent?** (the celebration of Jesus' Resurrection) **What do we focus on during Lent?** (our relationship with God, the needs of others, and how we can do more to help others)

2 Connect

Words I Learned Write *almsgiving* on the board and pronounce it. Ask children to suggest words or phrases that clarify the meaning of the word. Do the same for *intercession*. Then ask children to tell something about the Prayer of the Faithful. Review the words in the Glossary if necessary.

Ways of Being Like Jesus Have a volunteer read aloud this section. Say: **Sometimes the best way to help people is simply to listen to what is worrying them or causing them trouble. Often just having a friend to talk to makes people feel better.**

ACTIVITY Read aloud the directions. When they have completed the diagram, ask children to give examples of each Lenten practice.



Prayer

Say: **Let's take a moment to pray to Jesus. We'll pray aloud together.** Read the prayer aloud together as a group. Then lead children in praying the Sign of the Cross, ending with *Amen*.

3 Go in Peace

Invite children to share this tear-out page with their families. To close this session, say: **Tell me some of the ways you've found to act more like Jesus. I'd like to hear your ideas!**

With My Family

Scripture Together

Jesus teaches us to give out of love and compassion.

As a family, read what Jesus teaches us about giving in **Matthew 6:1-4**. When you have finished, discuss the Scripture. Use the questions below to guide you:

- How does Jesus say a person should give alms?
- Describe a time when you helped someone without calling attention to what you did.
- How does it help the family when you contribute quietly without expecting praise or a reward every time?



Family Prayer

Pray together:

Dear Lord, help us know that our reward for giving of ourselves and what we have is in growing closer to you. Amen.

Faith on the Go

Ask one another: *What are some ways our family can practice prayer and giving together, during Lent and at all other times?*

ACTIVITY: A Family Service Project

Think of a service you can perform as a family for the parish or your neighborhood. Make a plan and carry it out.



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IF TIME ALLOWS



ACCESS Fishers of Faith.



ASSESSMENT

Session Assessment Option

A session assessment can be found at www.findinggod.com.

Unit Assessment Option

If you wish, photocopy the Unit Assessment. Administer the assessment during the session or send it home.

PLAN AHEAD: Get Ready for Session 21

Consult the catechist preparation pages to prepare for Session 21 and determine any materials you will need.